

ACT ONE · SUBJECT · VERB · OBJECT

Six Characters in Search of an Author

Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore

The Action of Act One, Line by Line

Every speech in Act One reduced to a single simple sentence — one subject, one verb, one object — with the original line printed beneath it.

A Village Players production

Lausanne

How to read this. Each entry is one speech from Act One, in performance order. The bold line is the **action** of the speech in the plainest form — who does what to what. The italic line below is the actual dialogue, for reference.

256 speeches in all.

ACT ONE — THE ACTION, SPEECH BY SPEECH

THE MANAGER

1

The Manager refuses the mail.

“No. No. Not another one. If it’s a bill, a complaint, or a note from somebody with “thoughts about the theatre,” burn it before I read it.”

PLAYER 2

2

Player Two delivers the envelope.

“It’s all three, sir. The same envelope.”

THE MANAGER

3

The Manager insults the room.

“And who opened this room? It looks like a waiting room for actors nobody called back.”

PLAYER 1

4

Player One accepts the casting.

“Then for once we are perfectly cast.”

THE MANAGER

5

The Manager demands light.

“Don’t be charming, sir — it costs extra, and we can’t afford it. A little light, please — if the house has any left to spare us this evening.”

PLAYER 2

6

Player Two offers half-light.

“Half light. It’s what’s left.”

THE MANAGER

7

The Manager mocks the budget.

“Half light, half a company, half a budget. We’re ready for Pirandello. God help us.”

8

THE MANAGER

The Manager calls the rehearsal.

"Come along! Second act of "Mixing It Up" — and play it, this once, as if you wanted the public back for the third."

9

PLAYER 1

Player One claims past success.

"The public came back for the third act once."

10

PLAYER 2

Player Two doubts the claim.

"For you?"

11

PLAYER 1

Player One keeps the credit.

"During me. There's a difference."

12

PLAYER 3

Player Three reads the setting.

"“Leo Gala's house. A curious room serving as dining-room and study.”"

13

THE MANAGER

The Manager orders the room.

"Fix up the old red room."

14

PLAYER 2

Player Two reports the change.

"The red room is blue now. We painted over it in March."

15

THE MANAGER

The Manager repeats the order.

"Then make it red."

16

PLAYER 2

Player Two mocks the budget.

"With what, sir? Hope? Same flats as the blue room. I'll turn them round."

17

PLAYER 3

Player Three reads the direction.

"“When the curtain rises, Leo Gala, in cook's cap and apron, is busy beating an egg in a cup...”"

18

THE MANAGER

The Manager cuts the eggs.

"Yes — real eggs, if the budget runs to it. Mime them."

19

PLAYER 1

Player One protests the cap.

"Excuse me. Must I absolutely wear a cook's cap?"

20

THE MANAGER

The Manager cites the book.

"It says so there."

21

PLAYER 1

Player One defends his reputation.

"But it's ridiculous. I have a reputation in this canton — fifteen years of it, and not one inch built on a cook's cap."

22

PLAYER 2

Player Two mocks his reputation.

"Fifteen years. And the cap is what finally finishes you."

23

THE MANAGER

The Manager defines the job.

"Ridiculous? Of course it's ridiculous — that is the whole job. We are paid to make ridiculous things look inevitable. So put on the cap, beat the egg, and become the shell."

24

PLAYER 1

Player One questions the shell.

"The shell?"

25

THE MANAGER

The Manager explains the shell.

"Empty, fragile, and cracked before the public arrives. Try not to overplay it. And is it my fault France keeps its good comedies for Paris and sends us Pirandello — whom nobody understands, least of all the people paid to perform him?"

26

PLAYER 1

Player One threatens resignation.

"I'd sooner resign."

27

PLAYER 2

Player Two mocks the resignation.

"He resigns every Tuesday."

28

PLAYER 1

Player One records his protest.

"Let the record show I wear it under protest."

29

THE MANAGER

The Manager notes the protest.

"The record is noted. The record is always noted. Chair, book — and somebody pretend we are a theatre."

30

PLAYER 3

Player Three requests his box.

"Pardon, sir — may I get into my box? There's a draught off that door they've still not mended, and I'd rather not be hoarse for my first proper season."

31

THE MANAGER

The Manager grants the box.

"Yes, yes — in, in."

32

PLAYER 3

Player Three questions the work.

"Do we ever rehearse anything real?"

33

THE MANAGER

The Manager dismisses reality.

"Real? God forbid. Real things ruin a rehearsal."

34

PLAYER 1

The Door-keeper announces visitors.

"Excuse me, sir — désolé to interrupt; I know you don't like the morning's work disturbed..."

35

THE MANAGER

The Manager asks the matter.

"Eb? What is it?"

36

PLAYER 1

The Door-keeper reports the visitors.

"These people are asking for you, sir. I did tell them you were busy. They insisted."

37

THE MANAGER

The Manager forbids interruption.

"I am rehearsing, and you know perfectly well no one's allowed to come in during rehearsals! Who are you, please? What do you want?"

38

THE FATHER

The Father seeks an author.

“Actually... we have come here in search of an author...”

39

THE MANAGER

The Manager questions the author.

“An author? What author?”

40

THE FATHER

The Father wants any author.

“Any author, sir.”

41

THE MANAGER

The Manager denies an author.

“But there's no author here. We are not rehearsing a new piece.”

42

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter offers themselves.

“So much the better, sir, so much the better. You can put us on tonight — we'll draw better than whatever you were rehearsing.”

43

PLAYER 3

Player Three mocks the offer.

“Oh — do you hear that?”

44

PLAYER 1

Player One defends the draw.

“We were drawing perfectly well. ...Adequately.”

45

THE FATHER

The Father proposes the Manager.

“Yes, but if the author isn't here... unless you would be willing...”

46

THE MANAGER

The Manager suspects a joke.

“You are trying to be funny. We have neither the time nor the budget for funny.”

47

THE FATHER

The Father brings a drama.

“No, for Heaven's sake, what are you saying? We bring you a drama, sir.”

48

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter promises fortune.

"We may be your fortune, sir — if you have the nerve for us."

49

THE MANAGER

The Manager dismisses the strangers.

"Will you oblige me by going away? Allez, please. We haven't time to waste with mad people. We have our own."

50

THE FATHER

The Father defends their truth.

"You call us mad because we come without a book. But isn't that your work — to make invented things seem true? We are true already. We only lack the stage."

51

THE MANAGER

The Manager praises the profession.

"But I beg you to believe, my dear sir, that the actor's profession is a noble one. If today's playwrights give us stupid comedies to play and puppets instead of real people, remember — we are proud to have given life to immortal works on these very boards."

52

THE FATHER

The Father exalts characters.

"Exactly, perfectly. To living beings more alive than those who breathe and wear clothes — beings less real, perhaps, but truer. Truer because they cannot lie about themselves the way we can. I agree with you entirely."

53

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter mocks his word.

"Truer. He has been using that word for years. Ask my mother how true it sounded."

54

THE MANAGER

The Manager notes the contradiction.

"But what do you mean? Before, you said..."

55

THE FATHER

The Father invokes imagination.

"No, sir. I mean only this: you know better than anyone that imagination gives bodies to things that would otherwise remain invisible."

56

THE MANAGER

The Manager demands the point.

"Very well, — but where does all this take us?"

57

THE FATHER

The Father claims their birth.

"Nowhere — only to show you we were born this way. Characters. Alive. And left without a stage."

58

THE MANAGER

The Manager mocks their birth.

"So you and these other friends of yours have been born characters?"

59

THE FATHER

The Father affirms their life.

"Exactly, and alive as you see!"

60

THE FATHER

The Father reveals the drama.

"I am sorry you laugh, because we carry in us a drama, as you can guess from this woman here veiled in black."

61

THE MANAGER

The Manager orders them out.

"Oh, enough! Out, please! Clear out of here! For Heaven's sake, turn them out!"

62

THE FATHER

The Father resists ejection.

"No, no, look here, we..."

63

THE MANAGER

The Manager asserts work.

"We come here to work, you know."

64

PLAYER 1

Player One refuses mockery.

"One cannot allow oneself to be made a fool of, not before lunch, anyway."

65

THE FATHER

The Father invokes their craft.

"Your disbelief amazes me, gentlemen. Aren't you used to seeing the characters created by an author spring to life in yourselves and face each other? Just because there is no "book" which contains us, you refuse to believe..."

66

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter names the six.

"Believe me, we are really six most interesting characters, sir; side-tracked however."

67

THE FATHER

The Father cites immortal characters.

"Sancho Panza lives. Madame Bovary lives. Their authors died, but they remain. We were born too — but left without a world to hold us."

68

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter mocks his repetition.

"He has said all this to himself before. Many times."

69

THE MANAGER

The Manager demands their purpose.

"That is quite all right. But what do you want here, all of you?"

70

THE FATHER

The Father wants life.

"We want to live."

71

THE MANAGER

The Manager mocks eternity.

"For Eternity?"

72

THE FATHER

The Father wants a moment.

"No, sir, only for a moment... in you."

73

PLAYER 2

Player Two mocks the request.

"They want to live, in us... as if there were room."

74

THE FATHER

The Father proposes the comedy.

"Look here! look here! The comedy has to be made. But if you and your actors are willing, we can soon arrange it among ourselves."

75

THE MANAGER

The Manager rejects arranging.

"But what do you want to arrange? We don't arrange things here. Here we play dramas, comedies, and — once a year, against my better judgment — a musical revue. Not whatever this is."

76

THE FATHER

The Father affirms their purpose.

“Exactly! That is just why we have come to you.”

77

THE MANAGER

The Manager demands the book.

“And where is the “book”?”

78

THE FATHER

The Father claims the drama.

“It is in us! The drama is in us, and we are the drama. We are impatient to play it. Our inner passion drives us on to this.”

79

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter mocks the word.

“His passion. Always the word passion.”

80

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter mocks her passion.

“My passion, sir. Ah, if you only knew — my passion for him.”

81

THE FATHER

The Father rebukes her laughter.

“Behave yourself! And please don’t laugh in that fashion.”

82

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter announces a song.

“With your permission, gentlemen, I, who am a two months’ orphan, will show you how well I can dance and sing. Don’t worry — it isn’t a hymn.”

83

PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & AMP; PLAYER 3

The Players applaud her.

“Bravo! Well done! Encore!”

84

THE MANAGER

The Manager silences the concert.

“Silence! This isn’t a café concert, you know! Is she mad?”

85

PLAYER 1

Player One praises her presence.

“She has more stage presence than the second act. I’ll say that.”

86

THE FATHER

The Father condemns her.

“Mad? No, she’s worse than mad.”

87

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter demands staging.

“Worse? Listen! Stage this drama now, sir! At a certain moment, when we lose this little darling, and this fool here does the stupidest thing — you will see me run away. Yes, gentlemen, I’ll be off. But the moment hasn’t come yet. After what has taken place between him and me, I can’t stay here, watching her anguish over that fool. Look at him — frigid, indifferent, because he is the legitimate son. He despises us all because we are bastards. And he won’t even recognise her as his mother. Wretch.”

88

THE MOTHER

The Mother begs the Manager.

“In the name of these two little children, I beg you... Oh God!”

89

THE FATHER

The Father calls a chair.

“Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!”

90

PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & AMP; PLAYER 3

The Players doubt the faint.

“Is it true? Has she really fainted?”

91

THE MANAGER

The Manager calls a chair.

“Quick, a chair! Here!”

92

THE FATHER

The Father displays the Mother.

“Look at her! Look at her!”

93

THE MOTHER

The Mother refuses exposure.

“No, no; stop it please!”

94

THE FATHER

The Father unveils her.

“Let them see you!”

95

THE MOTHER

The Mother begs him stop.

"I beg you, sir. Stop him. I cannot bear what he wants to do."

96

THE MANAGER

The Manager questions the wife.

"I don't understand at all. What is the situation? Is this lady your wife?"

97

THE FATHER

The Father claims his wife.

"Yes, gentlemen: my wife!"

98

THE MANAGER

The Manager questions the widow.

"But how can she be a widow if you are alive?"

99

THE FATHER

The Father explains her lover.

"Don't laugh! Don't laugh like that, for Heaven's sake. Her drama lies just here in this: she has had a lover, a man who should be here."

100

THE MOTHER

The Mother denies it.

"No! No!"

101

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter reports his death.

"Fortunately for her, sir, he is dead. Two months ago, as I said. We are in mourning, as you see. Most respectable."

102

THE FATHER

The Father defines her drama.

"He isn't here, you see, not because he is dead. He isn't here because her drama is not a drama of love at all. She felt nothing for either of us — perhaps a little gratitude, not for me, for the other. She isn't a woman, she is a mother. And her drama — powerful sir, I assure you — lies all in these four children she has had by two men."

103

THE MOTHER

The Mother blames the Father.

"I had them? Have you got the courage to say that I wanted them? It was him. He gave me to that other man. He made me go."

104

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter contradicts her.

"It isn't true."

105

THE MOTHER

The Mother challenges the denial.

"Not true, isn't it?"

106

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter repeats the denial.

"No, it isn't true, it just isn't true."

107

THE MOTHER

The Mother questions her knowledge.

"And what can you know about it?"

108

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter exposes the reason.

"It isn't true. Don't believe it. Do you know why she says so? For that fellow there. She tortures herself, destroys herself on account of the neglect of that son there; and she wants him to believe that if she abandoned him when he was only two years old, it was because he made her do so."

109

THE MOTHER

The Mother swears the truth.

"He forced me to it. And I call God to witness it. Ask him if it isn't true. Let him speak. You are not in a position to know anything about it."

110

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter recalls the happiness.

"I know you lived in peace and happiness with my father while he lived. Can you deny it?"

111

THE MOTHER

The Mother admits the happiness.

"No, I don't deny it..."

112

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter presses the Boy.

"He was always full of affection and kindness for you. It's true, isn't it? Tell them! Why don't you speak, you little fool?"

113

THE MOTHER

The Mother defends herself.

"Leave him alone. Why do you want to make me appear ungrateful, daughter? I don't want to offend your father. I have told him: I did not leave my house and my son through any fault of mine. Not from any wilful passion."

114

THE FATHER

The Father confesses the deed.

"It's true. It was my doing."

115

PLAYER 1

Player One admires the spectacle.

"What a spectacle. What an absolute..."

116

PLAYER 2

Player Two claims the audience.

"We are the audience this time."

117

PLAYER 3

Player Three echoes the moment.

"For once."

118

THE MANAGER

The Manager demands attention.

"Let's bear them out. Listen!"

119

THE SON

The Son mocks the Father.

"Oh yes, you're going to hear a fine bit now. He will talk to you of the Demon of Experiment."

120

THE FATHER

The Father insults the Son.

"You are a cynical imbecile. I've told you so already a hundred times. He tries to make fun of me on account of this expression which I have found to excuse myself with."

121

THE SON

The Son dismisses the phrases.

"Yes. Phrases. Phrases."

122

THE FATHER

The Father defends the phrases.

“Phrases! Isn’t everyone consoled when faced with a trouble or fact he doesn’t understand, by a word, some simple word, which tells us nothing and yet calms us?”

123

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter names remorse.

“Even remorse. Especially remorse.”

124

THE FATHER

The Father denies remorse.

“Remorse? No, that isn’t true. I’ve done more than use words to quieten the remorse in me.”

125

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter reveals the money.

“Yes, there was money. A nice little bit. The hundred francs he was about to lay down for me, gentlemen — and I two months an orphan.”

126

THE SON

The Son condemns it.

“This is vile.”

127

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter names the shop.

“Vile? There they were in a pale blue envelope on a little mahogany table in the back of Madame Pace’s shop. You know Madame Pace, sir — one of those ladies who take in poor girls of good family on the pretext of selling robes et manteaux. The pretext is always robes. The arrangement is always something else.”

128

THE SON

The Son exposes the payment.

“And he thinks he bought the right to tyrannize over us with that hundred francs. Which — note this, gentlemen — he never got the chance to pay.”

129

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter mocks the timing.

“It was a near thing, though, you know!”

130

THE MOTHER

The Mother shames her daughter.

“Shame, my daughter. Not in front of her.”

131

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter claims the scene.

"Shame? Oh, the shame is mine — and the revenge. I am dying to live that scene. The room — I see it. Here is the window with the mantles in display, there the divan, the looking-glass, a screen, and in front of the window the little mahogany table with the blue envelope and its hundred francs. I see it. I can almost take hold of it. But you, gentlemen, might look elsewhere for this part of it. I do not blush, however. He does."

132

THE MANAGER

The Manager admits confusion.

"I don't understand this at all."

133

THE FATHER

The Father demands the explanation.

"Of course. — Sir. Before you decide what she has just put on me, you must let me explain."

134

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter mocks the explanation.

"Ah yes, explain it in your own way."

135

THE FATHER

The Father blames words.

"Words are the whole trouble. I say one thing, she hears another. I try to explain myself — and the explanation becomes another crime."

136

THE MOTHER

The Mother accuses the Father.

"But you drove me away."

137

THE FATHER

The Father mocks her belief.

"Do you hear her? I drove her away! She believes I really sent her away."

138

THE MOTHER

The Mother recalls her humility.

"You know how to talk, and I don't. But believe me, sir — after he had married me... who knows why?... I was a poor woman. Nothing."

139

THE FATHER

The Father explains the marriage.

"— it was for your humility that I married you. I loved this simplicity in you. You see — she denies it. She cannot hear me. She has never been able to hear me. She has a heart for the children. When I speak — nothing."

140

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter mocks his intelligence.

"Yes, but ask him how his intelligence has helped us."

141

THE FATHER

The Father laments good intentions.

"If we could see all the evil that can come from good, what would we do?"

142

PLAYER 2

Player Two questions the rehearsal.

"Excuse me — mais sérieusement — are we going to rehearse today, or have we converted to a lecture series?"

143

THE MANAGER

The Manager delays the rehearsal.

"Of course, of course; but let's hear them out."

144

PLAYER 1

Player One mocks the lesson.

"Most interesting. In a kind of educational way."

145

PLAYER 2

Player Two defends the actors.

"Yes — for the kind of audience that goes in for that kind of evening. The rest of us are working actors. We have rent to pay."

146

THE MANAGER

The Manager demands clarity.

"You must please explain yourself quite clearly."

147

THE FATHER

The Father introduces the secretary.

"Very well then: listen! I had in my service a poor man, a clerk, a secretary of mine, full of devotion, who became friends with her. They understood each other, kindred souls in fact, without the slightest suspicion of evil between them. They were incapable even of thinking of it."

148

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter twists the motive.

"So he thought of it — for them!"

149

THE FATHER

The Father denies the motive.

“That’s not true. I meant to do good to them — and to myself, I confess, at the same time. Things had reached the point where I couldn’t say a word to either of them without their making a silent appeal to each other with their eyes. I could see them silently asking each other how to keep me calm, how to keep me quiet. And this alone, believe me, was enough to keep me in a constant rage — to exasperate me beyond measure.”

150

THE MANAGER

The Manager questions the dismissal.

“And why didn’t you send him away then — this secretary of yours?”

151

THE FATHER

The Father recalls the dismissal.

“Precisely what I did, sir. And then I had to watch this poor woman wandering the house like an animal without a master. Like an animal one has taken in out of pity.”

152

THE MOTHER

The Mother sighs assent.

“Ah yes...”

153

THE FATHER

The Father confirms the son.

“It’s true about the son anyway, isn’t it?”

154

THE MOTHER

The Mother mourns the son.

“He took my son away from me first of all.”

155

THE FATHER

The Father justifies the removal.

“But not from cruelty. I did it so that he should grow up healthy and strong by living in the country.”

156

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter mocks the result.

“As one can see.”

157

THE FATHER

The Father blames the upbringing.

“Is it my fault if he has grown up like this? I sent him to a wet nurse in the country, a peasant, as his mother did not seem strong enough. That, sir, was the reason I married her. Unpleasant — but how can it be helped? All my life I have had these damned aspirations toward a moral sanity I never quite reach.”

158

THE MANAGER

The Manager begs him stop.

“Yes, please stop it, for Heaven’s sake.”

159

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter exposes his hypocrisy.

“But imagine moral sanity from him, if you please — a regular customer of Madame Pace’s shop. A very regular customer.”

160

PLAYER 1

Player One disowns the play.

“— These are not the lines of a play I auditioned for.”

161

THE FATHER

The Father proclaims his manhood.

“Fool! That is the proof that I am a man. This seeming contradiction, gentlemen, is the strongest proof that I stand here a live man before you. It is precisely this incongruity in my nature that has made me suffer what I have suffered. I couldn’t live beside that woman any longer; not so much for the boredom she inspired in me, as for the pity I felt for her.”

162

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter names the crime.

“He calls it pity. He was caught buying his stepdaughter in the back of a dressmaker’s shop. He calls it pity.”

163

THE MOTHER

The Mother recalls her expulsion.

“And so he turned me out —.”

164

THE FATHER

The Father claims her provision.

“— well provided for! Yes, I sent her to that man, gentlemen... to let her go free of me.”

165

THE MOTHER

The Mother names his freedom.

“And to free himself.”

166

THE FATHER

The Father admits the liberation.

“Yes. I admit it. It was a liberation, also, for me. But great evil has come of it. I meant well, sir. I did it for her sake more than for mine — I have never once doubted it. Did I ever lose sight of you, until that other man carried you off to another town? Out of pure interest in you, with no base motive in it, I watched — from a long way off — the new family that grew up around her.”

167

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter recalls his watching.

“Oh yes, that’s true enough. When I was little, so high, you know, with plaits over my shoulders and my skirt down past my knees, I used to see him waiting outside the school for me to come out. He came, sir, to see how I was growing up.”

168

THE FATHER

The Father condemns her words.

“This is infamous, shameful!”

169

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter dismisses the shame.

“No. Why?”

170

THE FATHER

The Father recalls the emptiness.

“Infamous! infamous! After she went away, my house seemed suddenly empty. She had been my nightmare, but she filled my house. I was like a dazed fly alone in the empty rooms. This boy here was educated away from home; when he came back, he seemed to me to be no more mine. With no mother between him and me, he grew up apart, on his own, with no tie of intellect or affection. And then — strange but true — I was driven, by curiosity at first and then by some tender sentiment, toward her family, which had come into being through my will. The thought of her began gradually to fill the emptiness I felt all around me.”

171

PLAYER 2

Player Two questions the record.

“Should we be writing this down? Some of it sounds important.”

172

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter recalls his gifts.

“Yes, yes. True. He used to follow me in the street and smile at me, wave his hand like this. I looked at him, doubtful, wondering who he might be. I told my mother, who guessed at once. Then she wouldn’t send me to school for some days. When I went back, there he was again — looking so ridiculous — with a paper parcel: a fine straw hat, a bouquet of flowers, all for me.”

173

THE MANAGER

The Manager calls it discursive.

“A bit discursive this, you know!”

174

THE SON

The Son dismisses literature.

“Literature. Literature.”

175

THE FATHER

The Father defends life.

"Literature indeed! This is life, this is passion!"

176

THE MANAGER

The Manager doubts the staging.

"It may be, but it won't act."

177

THE FATHER

The Father defers the drama.

"I agree. This is only the part leading up. I don't suggest this should be staged. She, as you see, is no longer the schoolgirl with plaits down her back —."

178

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter finishes the memory.

"— and the skirt down past the knee!"

179

THE FATHER

The Father promises the drama.

"The drama is coming now, sir; something new, complex, most interesting."

180

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter recalls the death.

"As soon as my father died..."

181

THE FATHER

The Father recalls their return.

"— there was absolute misery for them. They came back here, without my knowing. She can barely write her own name; but she could at least have had her daughter write — to tell me that they were in need."

182

THE MOTHER

The Mother pleads ignorance.

"And how was I to divine all this sentiment in him?"

183

THE FATHER

The Father blames her blindness.

"That is exactly your mistake, never to have guessed any of my sentiments."

184

THE MOTHER

The Mother recalls the years.

"After so many years apart, and all that had happened..."

185

THE FATHER

The Father blames the lover.

“Was it my fault if that fellow carried you away? After he had found some job, I could find no trace of them — and, naturally, my interest dwindled. But the drama culminated, unforeseen, on their return — when I was driven by the loneliness that still had its grip on me. Ah, what wretchedness is in the man who is alone, and too proud for the shabby, easy comforts. Not old enough to do without company. Not young enough to seek it without shame. It is worse than misery. Every man carries things in the secrecy of his own heart that he would never say aloud. One gives way to a moment's weakness, and then rises from it, and is himself again — and the moment is not the man. Most men simply haven't the courage to admit the moment was ever there at all. That is the only difference between us. That's all.”

186

PLAYER 1

Player One withholds his questions.

“I have several questions. None of them are polite.”

187

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter names the courage.

“All appear to have the courage to do them though.”

188

THE FATHER

The Father defends the confession.

“Yes, but in secret. Let a man only speak them out, and folks at once label him a cynic. But he is like all the others — he only admits, with the light of intelligence, the plain shame in all of us that most men prefer to close their eyes upon. Two people drift toward a thing neither will name; the moment they are caught at it, they both look away. It is the way we tell each other: blind yourself, because I have.”

189

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter exposes the gaze.

“Sometimes one of the two cannot look away any more — when she no longer feels the need of hiding her shame from herself, but dry-eyed and dispassionately sees only the shame of the man who has blinded himself without love. Oh, all this philosophy that uncovers the worst in a man and then seeks to excuse him — I can't stand it, sir. When a man simplifies life down to appetite, throwing aside every finer aspiration, every sense of duty, modesty, shame — then nothing is more revolting than the remorse that follows. Crocodile's tears, that's what it is.”

190

THE MANAGER

The Manager demands the point.

“Let's come to the point. This is only discussion.”

191

THE FATHER

The Father defends the reasons.

“Very good, sir! A fact is like a sack — it won't stand up when it's empty. For it to stand up, you have to put into it the reason and sentiment which have caused it to exist. I couldn't possibly know that after his death they had decided to come back here, that they were in misery, and that she had gone to work as a seamstress, in a shop of Madame Pace's kind.”

192

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter describes the modiste.

“A real high-class modiste, gentlemen. In appearance she dresses the leaders of the best society — but she arranges matters so those elegant ladies serve her purpose, and the rest of us — well, the rest of us serve a rather different purpose.”

193

THE MOTHER

The Mother recalls the trap.

“You will believe me, gentlemen, that it never entered my mind that the old hag offered me work because she had her eye on my daughter.”

194

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter exposes the woman.

“Poor Mother! Do you know, sir, what that woman did when I brought her back the work my mother had finished? She would point out to me that I had torn one of my dresses, and she would give it back to my mother to mend. It was I who paid for it, always I; while this poor creature here believed she was sacrificing herself for me and these two children here, sitting up at night sewing Madame Pace’s dresses.”

195

THE MANAGER

The Manager anticipates the meeting.

“And one day you met there...”

196

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter names the client.

“Him, him. Yes sir, an old client. There’s a scene for you to play! Superb!”

197

THE FATHER

The Father recalls her arrival.

“She, the Mother arrived just then...”

198

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter mocks the timing.

“Almost in time.”

199

THE FATHER

The Father insists on rescue.

“No — in time. In time. Fortunately I recognized her... in time. And I took them back home with me to my house. You can imagine now her position and mine; she, as you see her, and I who cannot look her in the face.”

200

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter rejects the role.

“Absurd! How can I possibly be expected — after that — to play the modest young miss, fit company for his damned aspirations of “a solid moral sanity”?”

201

THE FATHER

The Father defends the moment.

“One moment is not a whole man. But she wants to nail me forever to that one room, that one table, that one envelope.”

202

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter accuses him alone.

“You walked into that room by yourself.”

203

PLAYER 2

Player Two names the confession.

“Pardon — did we just witness a confession?”

204

THE SON

The Son rejects the drama.

“Leave me alone. I don’t come into this.”

205

THE FATHER

The Father challenges the Son.

“What? You don’t come into this?”

206

THE SON

The Son disowns the family.

“I’ve got nothing to do with it. And I don’t want to have. You know perfectly well I wasn’t made to be mixed up in all this with the rest of you.”

207

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter mocks his gentility.

“We are vulgar folk, sir. He is the fine gentleman. You may have noticed, Mr. Manager, that I fix him now and again with a look that makes him lower his eyes — because he knows what he did to me.”

208

THE SON

The Son feigns innocence.

“I?”

209

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter blames the Son.

“You — you! I owe my life on the streets to you. Did you, or did you not, deny us — I won’t say the warmth of home, but even the bare hospitality that makes a guest feel at ease? We were intruders, come to disturb the kingdom of your legitimacy. I’d like Mr. Manager to witness certain scenes between him and me. He says I have tyrannised. It was his behaviour that made me insist on the reason I had come — with my mother, who is his mother too. And I came as mistress of the house.”

210

THE SON

The Son pities his position.

"It's easy for them to put me always in the wrong. But imagine, gentlemen, the position of a son who sees arrive one day at his home a young woman of impudent bearing, asking for his father — with whom, who knows what business she has. Then she returns, bolder, with that child there. He has to watch her treat his father in an equivocal and confidential manner. She asks him for money — in a way that lets one suppose he must give it. Must. Because he has every obligation."

211

THE FATHER

The Father claims the obligation.

"But I have, in fact, this obligation. I owe it to your mother."

212

THE SON

The Son denies the mother.

"How should I know? When had I ever seen or heard of her? One day there arrive with her that lad and this baby here. I am told: "This is your mother. Also." I divine from her manner why they have come home. I had rather not say what I feel about it. I shouldn't even care to confess it to myself. No action can therefore be hoped for from me in this affair. Believe me, sir — I am an "unrealised" character. Leave me out of it, I beg you."

213

THE FATHER

The Father presses the Son.

"What? It is just because you are so that..."

214

THE SON

The Son rejects the Father.

"How do you know what I am like? When did you ever bother your head about me?"

215

THE SON

The Son names his guilt.

"You all need me because somebody must be guilty who did nothing."

216

THE FATHER

The Father admits his neglect.

"I admit it. I admit it. But isn't that a situation in itself? This aloofness of yours, so cruel to me and to your mother, who comes home and sees you almost for the first time as a grown man, who doesn't recognise you but knows you are her son... See, she's crying!"

217

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter mocks the Mother.

"Like a fool."

218

THE FATHER

The Father defines the Son.

"She can't stand him, you know. He says he doesn't come into the affair, whereas he is really the hinge of the whole action. Look at that lad who is always clinging to his mother, frightened and humiliated. It is on account of this fellow here. Possibly his situation is the most painful of all. He feels himself more a stranger than the others — mortified at being brought into a home out of charity, as it were. The image of his father. Hardly talks at all."

219

THE MANAGER

The Manager cuts the boy.

"Oh, we'll cut him out. You've no notion what a nuisance boys are on the stage..."

220

THE FATHER

The Father foretells the ending.

"The little girl vanishes first. Then the boy. Then she runs. And what remains? Three people in the same house, unable to belong to one another. A family, perhaps — but without faith, without warmth, without any place where happiness could take root."

221

THE MANAGER

The Manager admits his interest.

"Damn it... there is something in what you say. I don't like it, but it interests me."

222

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter claims the part.

"When you've got a character like me."

223

THE FATHER

The Father silences her.

"You be quiet!"

224

THE MANAGER

The Manager weighs the idea.

"It's new... hem... yes... You've got a nerve, though — to come here and fling it at me like this."

225

THE FATHER

The Father claims the stage.

"You will understand, sir, born as we are for the stage..."

226

THE MANAGER

The Manager asserts professionalism.

"Are you amateur actors then? Because we, sir, are a professional company, with a season to fill."

227

THE FATHER

The Father clarifies himself.

"No. I say born for the stage, because..."

228

THE MANAGER

The Manager dismisses the claim.

"Oh, nonsense. You're an old hand, you know."

229

THE FATHER

The Father rejects amateurism.

"No, sir. We do not act like amateurs. We live the roles life has cast us in."

230

THE MANAGER

The Manager offers an author.

"Well, well, that will do. But you see, without an author... I could give you the address of an author if you like..."

231

THE FATHER

The Father names the Manager.

"No, no. Look here! You must be the author. You need not invent us — only give us form."

232

THE MANAGER

The Manager refuses the role.

"I? What are you talking about?"

233

THE FATHER

The Father presses the Manager.

"Yes, you, you! Why not?"

234

THE MANAGER

The Manager denies the skill.

"Because I have never been an author: that's why."

235

THE FATHER

The Father redefines the task.

"Then become one now — not by inventing, sir, but by listening. We are already here. You need only take us down."

236

THE MANAGER

The Manager rejects the plan.

"It won't do."

237

THE FATHER

The Father invokes their drama.

“What? When you see us live our drama...”

238

THE MANAGER

The Manager demands a writer.

“Yes, that’s all right. But you want someone to write it.”

239

THE FATHER

The Father proposes transcription.

“No, no. Someone to take it down, possibly, while we play it, scene by scene! It will be enough to sketch it out at first, and then try it over.”

240

THE MANAGER

The Manager weakens toward yes.

“Well... I am almost tempted. It’s a bit of an idea. One might have a shot at it.”

241

THE FATHER

The Father offers a scene.

“Of course. You’ll see what scenes will come out of it. I can give you one, at once...”

242

THE MANAGER

The Manager accepts the temptation.

“God help me, it tempts me. I ought to throw you out — and instead I want to see the first scene. Come to my office. We’ll see what can be done.”

243

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

The Step-Daughter guards her scene.

“Extraordinary, yes — if he does not get to tell it alone.”

244

THE FATHER

The Father gathers the characters.

“There’s no doubt about it. They had better come with us too, hadn’t they?”

245

THE MANAGER

The Manager summons everyone.

“Yes, yes. Come on! come on! Be punctual, please!”

246

PLAYER 1

Player One resents the strangers.

“Is he serious? He has taken six strangers into his office and left us standing here like furniture.”

247

PLAYER 3

Player Three defends the strangers.

"They are not ordinary strangers."

248

PLAYER 2

Player Two names the tragedy.

"No. Ordinary strangers do not arrive with a tragedy already rehearsed."

249

PLAYER 1

Player One doubts the play.

"And now he wants us to make a play out of them. In twenty minutes."

250

PLAYER 3

Player Three suspects a play.

"Perhaps there is a play."

251

PLAYER 2

Player Two questions the pay.

"There is always a play. The question is whether anyone is being paid to be in it."

252

PLAYER 1 (AS DOOR-KEEPER)

The Door-keeper excuses himself.

"I only let them in."

253

PLAYER 2

Player Two rejects the excuse.

"That is not a defence."

254

PLAYER 1

Player One blames their look.

"They looked expected."

255

PLAYER 3

Player Three questions the notes.

"Am I taking this down?"

256

PLAYER 2

Player Two demands evidence.

"Take everything down. It may be evidence."

